



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-153
FIRST IN COUNCIL
August 3, 2026

COUNCILLOR NOLAN
COUNCILLOR SOBRINHO-WHEELER

- WHEREAS: The Massachusetts 2026 legislative session is considering many climate-related issues that will impact municipal operations, ratepayer bills, energy production, and the climate crisis more broadly; and
- WHEREAS: The Office of Sustainability as well as local advocates have followed these bills closely and have continued to advocate for strong climate legislation and will continue to as bills are sent to conference committee; and
- WHEREAS: It is important that there are no budget cuts to Mass Save and ACP funding: this critical funding is important for every municipality, and helps fund much of the work in Cambridge for residents of all incomes; and adequate funding of \$500 million over five years for the Municipal Vulnerability Preparedness grant program is necessary for environmental justice; and
- WHEREAS: Saving ratepayers money through utility accountability: the Senate version phases out the Gas System Enhancement Plan (GSEP) by 2030, saving ratepayers \$1.46 billion and prohibits utilities from using ratepayer money for lobbying expenses; it would be best for the commonwealth to phase out GSEP which had good intentions and recently has contributed to costs without reducing emission pollution, counter to our collective goal; and
- WHEREAS: Stronger data center protections: Cambridge is starting to explore how to regulate data centers of the size that operate in our city now and in the future and it is essential for the legislature to ensure widespread protections from the energy, noise, water, and energy bill impacts the data centers bring; and
- WHEREAS: Third party electric supplier protections: in Cambridge, disproportionately low-income residents are convinced to sign up for predatory third-party electricity supplier contracts, and that environmental injustice needs to be corrected, and it would be best for our city to be able to ban competitive electric suppliers and keep our existing, cost-effective and climate-friendly municipal aggregation plan; and
- WHEREAS: Environmental Bond Bill: support a provision in the Senate version of the Environmental Bond Bill (S.3050) that provides \$15 million for the development of thermal energy networks (TENs), especially ones operated by municipalities; and the need to ensure that TEN financing will be paid by entities benefitting from the TEN which may be expanded over time and all steps should be taken to allow utilities to develop TENs; and

WHEREAS: Energy Affordability Bill: support a provision in the Senate version of the Energy Affordability Bill (S.3143) establishing a working group to recommend legislative and regulatory changes to enable municipalities and public entities to own, install, operate, or bill for clean thermal energy systems; this working group would begin to resolve the current legal ambiguity surrounding local government ownership; and

WHEREAS: It is important that the City Council continue to advocate for state action that can support our own climate goals and City operations targeted at carbon emissions reduction and energy affordability for residents; now therefore be it

ORDERED: That the Cambridge City Council go on record in support of the initiatives in the above-referenced House and Senate bills as priorities for the deliberation of the conference committee and for inclusion in the final bill, in order to support the climate and affordability initiatives of the City of Cambridge; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Clerk be and hereby is requested to send a copy of this resolution to each member of the Cambridge delegation to the state legislature, the members of the conference committee, as well as the House Speaker and the Senate President on behalf of the entire City Council.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-



Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

That the Cambridge City Council in support of the initiatives in the House and Senate Environmental Bond Bill and the Energy Affordability Bill as priorities for the deliberation of the conference committee and for inclusion in the final bill, in order to support the climate and affordability initiatives of the City of Cambridge.